

Cox 1997 Claude Guide

Cox, Gary W. *Making Votes Count: Strategic Coordination in the World's Electoral Systems.*

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Contents

1	Central Claims	2
2	Key Concepts and Terms	3
3	Core Cases and Data	5
4	Core Works Cited / Engaged	6
5	Part I: Theory — Strategic Coordination and the $M + 1$ Rule	7
6	Part II: Applications I — Testing the $M + 1$ Rule (Plurality, SNTV, STV Cases)	8
7	Part III: Applications II — Cross-District Coordination and National Party Systems	9
8	Conclusion	9

1 Central Claims

- The book’s animating puzzle: the number of parties/candidates that actually compete and win votes in a democracy is not simply given by the number of salient social cleavages (the standard sociological view associated with Lipset and Rokkan), nor is it a mechanical artifact of the electoral formula alone. Instead, the number of viable competitors is the joint product of (1) the number of cleavages/interests in society wanting representation and (2) the **permissiveness** of electoral institutions, mediated by the **strategic coordination** of elites and voters.
- Cox reframes **Duverger’s Law** (“plurality rule favors two-party competition”) and **Duverger’s Hypothesis** (“PR favors multipartism”) as special cases of a more general theory of strategic coordination that applies to *any* electoral system, not just plurality and list-PR. The generalization is built around **district magnitude** (M , the number of seats elected in a district) as the key institutional variable, rather than the plurality/PR dichotomy per se.
- Central mechanism: rational, forward-looking voters and elites (candidates, parties, campaign contributors) have incentives to avoid “wasting” votes or resources on candidates/parties with no realistic chance of winning a seat. This generates two linked strategic behaviors: **strategic voting** (voters desert hopeless candidates for viable ones) and **strategic entry/exit** (elites decide whether to enter a race, and withdraw or refrain from entering, based on anticipated viability), which Cox jointly labels **strategic coordination**.
- The headline formal result is the $M + 1$ **rule**: in electoral systems with district magnitude M , rational strategic coordination should, under specified conditions, reduce the number of viable candidates/parties competing in *each district* to at most $M + 1$. Plurality rule ($M = 1$) yields Duverger’s classic two-candidate prediction as the special case $M + 1 = 2$; the rule generalizes this logic to multi-member districts (e.g., SNTV, STV) where more than two candidates can be viable.
- Cox distinguishes sharply between the **district-level** coordination that the $M + 1$ rule governs and the **national/system-level** number of parties (Duverger’s original concern). Even where district-level coordination is Duvergerian (competition narrows to $M + 1$), the *national* party system can still support many parties if district-level winners differ across districts and are not **linked** across districts—i.e., district-level reduction does not automatically aggregate into national-level reduction.
- This yields the book’s second major theoretical contribution: a theory of **cross-district (upper-tier) coordination**—why and how national party systems become more consolidated than the district-by-district $M + 1$ logic alone would predict. Cross-district linkage requires elites and voters in different districts to coordinate around the *same* small set of national parties/labels, which depends on factors like national party organization, presidential elections, and upper-tier (nationwide) seat allocation in mixed systems.
- **Presidential elections** are identified as a particularly powerful coordinating device: be-

cause the presidency is a single, national $M = 1$ prize, competition for it pulls legislative party systems toward two dominant blocs as well (an extension/refinement of **coattail effects** and Duverger-style logic to presidentialism), especially when presidential and legislative elections are concurrent.

- Cox explicitly theorizes **deviations from Duverger’s Law**—i.e., why plurality systems sometimes sustain more than two viable candidates at the district level—as **coordination failures**, arising from short time horizons, weak or absent common information (polls) that would let voters/elites identify the top $M + 1$ contenders, lack of common preference orderings across the electorate, or entry by candidates who are not simply vote-maximizing (e.g., who value running for non-electoral reasons).
- Methodologically, the book is a landmark integration of rational-choice/formal modeling (spatial and game-theoretic models of voter and elite strategic behavior) with wide comparative empirical testing—cross-national statistical analysis of legislative party systems, plus detailed within-case studies (Britain, Canada, India, Japan, Chile, Colombia, Brazil, the U.S., and others) chosen to isolate specific mechanisms (SNTV coordination, upper-tier linkage, presidential coattails).
- Normatively and disciplinarily, the book displaced the older sociological (cleavage-driven) and purely mechanical (electoral-formula-driven) accounts of party system size, establishing strategic coordination under specified informational and institutional conditions as the dominant framework in the subsequent electoral-systems literature.

2 Key Concepts and Terms

- **Duverger’s Law:** The proposition that single-member plurality (“first-past-the-post”) electoral rules favor two-party (two-candidate-per-district) competition.
- **Duverger’s Hypothesis:** The weaker, companion proposition that proportional representation (and other non-plurality rules) favor multipartism—treated by Duverger as a tendency rather than a law.
- **District magnitude (M):** The number of seats allocated in a given electoral district; Cox’s key generalizing variable, replacing the plurality/PR dichotomy as the primary institutional driver of the number of viable competitors.
- **The $M + 1$ rule:** Cox’s central formal prediction—strategic coordination among rational voters and elites should, under Duvergerian conditions, limit the number of viable candidates/parties in a district to $M + 1$, generalizing Duverger’s Law ($M = 1 \rightarrow 2$ candidates) to any district magnitude.
- **Strategic voting:** Voters casting ballots for a candidate/party other than their most preferred one because their preferred choice is perceived as non-viable (unable to win), in order to avoid “wasting” their vote.

- **Strategic entry (and exit):** Elites' (candidates', parties', contributors') decisions about whether to enter, remain in, or withdraw from a race based on anticipated electoral viability—the elite-level analogue to strategic voting, jointly constituting **strategic coordination**.
- **Sincere voting:** The baseline case in which voters cast ballots for their most-preferred candidate/party regardless of viability; the counterfactual against which strategic voting is defined.
- **Coordination failure:** A situation in which strategic coordination does not occur (or occurs incompletely), so that more than $M + 1$ candidates remain viable/receive substantial votes in a district—Cox's reframing of empirical deviations from Duverger's Law as failures of a coordination process rather than as simple falsifications of the theory.
- **Duvergerian equilibrium:** An equilibrium outcome in which exactly $M + 1$ candidates/parties are viable in a district and all rational voters/elites have coordinated accordingly; the theoretical benchmark outcome under the $M + 1$ logic.
- **Non-Duvergerian (or under/over-competitive) equilibrium:** Equilibria sustaining more (or, in some treatments, fewer) than $M + 1$ viable candidates, arising from multiple equilibria in the coordination game, divergent expectations, or heterogeneous voter information.
- **Common expectations / information (e.g., polls):** A key condition for successful strategic coordination—voters and elites need shared, reasonably accurate beliefs about which candidates are viable (e.g., via reliable pre-election polling or past election results) in order to coordinate on the same $M + 1$ contenders; absent this, coordination failures are more likely.
- **Short time horizons / new or volatile electorates:** Conditions Cox identifies as impeding coordination—in new democracies, newly enfranchised electorates, or highly volatile party systems, voters and elites lack the repeated-play experience and common information needed to coordinate efficiently, producing more coordination failures (relevant to cases like India and new democracies more broadly).
- **Cross-district (upper-tier) coordination:** The process by which district-level winners across many districts converge on the *same* small set of national party labels, so that district-level Duvergerian reduction (to $M + 1$ locally) aggregates into a small *national* party system rather than a large one built from many different local $M + 1$ pairs/sets.
- **Linkage:** The condition under which parties/candidates are connected across districts (via shared national labels, party organization, resource pooling, or coordinated upper-tier seat allocation in mixed-member systems) such that district-level and national-level party systems move together.
- **Coattail effects / presidential coordination:** The tendency of a concurrent, nationally contested, single-prize presidential race ($M = 1$ nationally) to pull legislative party

competition toward two dominant blocs as well, since presidential coordination incentives spill over into legislative strategic voting and entry.

- **SNTV (Single Non-Transferable Vote):** A multi-member-district system (used historically in Japan, and in Taiwan) in which each voter casts one vote for a single candidate, and the top M vote-getters win seats; a key testing ground for the $M + 1$ rule because it generates multi-candidate strategic coordination problems within intra-party as well as inter-party competition (co-partisans competing against each other for the same finite pool of votes).
- **STV (Single Transferable Vote):** A multi-member preferential system (e.g., Ireland) in which voters rank candidates and votes transfer via quotas; another test case for generalizing strategic coordination logic beyond simple plurality.
- **Effective number of (elective/legislative) parties:** A standard quantitative measure (building on Laakso and Taagepera) used throughout the book’s empirical chapters to operationalize “how many parties” compete or win seats, both at the district and national level.
- **Upper tier / mixed-member systems:** Electoral systems combining lower-tier single- or multi-member districts with an upper (compensatory or parallel) nationwide or regional tier; used by Cox to study how the design of the upper tier affects cross-district coordination and national party-system size.

3 Core Cases and Data

- **Britain and Canada (plurality systems):** Classic single-member plurality cases used to test the baseline $M + 1 = 2$ (Duvergerian) prediction and to probe why some plurality-system districts nonetheless sustain three or more viable candidates (e.g., regionally concentrated third parties), illustrating both successful coordination and its limits.
- **India:** A large- N within-country test of coordination under adverse conditions—many districts, a young and socially heterogeneous electorate, and limited common information—used to show that coordination failures (more than $M + 1$ viable candidates) are systematically more likely where voters lack the experience/information needed to identify jointly which candidates are truly viable.
- **Japan and Taiwan (SNTV):** The book’s central test of the generalized $M + 1$ rule beyond plurality—under SNTV, parties (especially the dominant LDP in Japan) must solve an internal coordination problem, allocating exactly the “right” number of co-partisan candidates across a multi-member district to avoid both wasted votes (too many candidates splitting the party’s support) and left-on-the-table seats (too few candidates).
- **Chile, Colombia, Brazil, and other Latin American/mixed cases:** Used to examine cross-district and upper-tier coordination dynamics, including how national party

organization and label-sharing (or its absence) shape whether district-level reduction aggregates into a small or large national party system.

- **The United States:** Referenced particularly in the discussion of presidential coordination/coattail effects, given its concurrent, single-prize national presidential race alongside single-member-district congressional elections.
- **Cross-national statistical analysis of legislative party systems:** A broad comparative dataset of district magnitude and (district- and national-level) effective number of parties/candidates across many democracies, used to test the $M + 1$ rule's core comparative-statics prediction that the (effective) number of viable competitors rises with M .

4 Core Works Cited / Engaged

- **Maurice Duverger**, *Political Parties: Their Organization and Activity in the Modern State* (1954)—the foundational statement of Duverger's Law and Hypothesis that the entire book generalizes, tests, and reframes around strategic coordination.
- **William H. Riker**, "The Two-Party System and Duverger's Law: An Essay on the History of Political Science" (1982, *American Political Science Review*)—the key prior rational-choice reformulation of Duverger's Law as an equilibrium outcome of strategic voting, which Cox builds on and substantially generalizes (especially beyond $M = 1$).
- **Seymour Martin Lipset and Stein Rokkan**, *Party Systems and Voter Alignments* (1967)—the classic sociological/cleavage-based account of party system size that Cox's institutionalist, strategic-coordination framework is positioned against (cleavages matter, but only interact with permissive/restrictive institutions to determine actual party system size).
- **Markku Laakso and Rein Taagepera**, "'Effective' Number of Parties: A Measure with Application to West Europe" (1979, *Comparative Political Studies*)—source of the effective-number-of-parties measure used throughout Cox's empirical chapters.
- **Rein Taagepera and Matthew Shugart**, *Seats and Votes: The Effects and Determinants of Electoral Systems* (1989)—closely related work on the mechanical and psychological effects of electoral systems on party system size; a key predecessor/interlocutor for Cox's district-magnitude-centered generalization.
- **Arend Lijphart**, comparative work on electoral systems and consensus vs. majoritarian democracy (e.g., *Electoral Systems and Party Systems*, 1994)—part of the broader comparative-institutionalist conversation on how electoral rules shape party systems that Cox's strategic-coordination account refines.
- **Kenneth Benoit**, and other scholars of strategic voting/entry in comparative context—part of the subsequent literature testing and extending the $M+1$ rule empirically, especially

in mixed-member and SNTV systems.

- **Steven Reed**, work on SNTV and the $M+1$ rule in Japan (e.g., “Structure and Behaviour: Extending Duverger’s Law to the Japanese Case”, 1990, *British Journal of Political Science*)—a direct precursor to Cox’s generalized treatment of SNTV coordination, explicitly engaged and extended in the Japan/Taiwan chapters.
- **Giovanni Sartori**, *Parties and Party Systems: A Framework for Analysis* (1976)—classic typological work on party systems and the classification of electoral formulae that forms part of the disciplinary backdrop Cox’s more formal, mechanism-based approach seeks to sharpen.

5 Part I: Theory — Strategic Coordination and the $M + 1$ Rule

- **Opening puzzle and framing:** Restates Duverger’s Law and Hypothesis, reviews their rational-choice reformulation (chiefly by Riker), and identifies the gap the book will fill—no existing theory explained party/candidate numbers across the *full range* of electoral systems (multi-member plurality-type systems like SNTV and STV, and mixed systems), only the polar plurality and list-PR cases.
- **Electoral systems as a continuum, not a dichotomy:** Rather than sorting systems into “plurality” vs. “PR” bins, Cox recasts electoral institutions along continuous dimensions—above all **district magnitude**—so that the same underlying strategic logic can, in principle, generate predictions for any system.
- **Strategic voting equilibria:** Develops the formal (game-theoretic/spatial) logic of why rational voters desert non-viable candidates, building on and generalizing Riker’s and Palfrey’s strategic-voting models from the two-candidate plurality case to general district magnitude M , deriving the $M + 1$ boundary on the number of candidates that can be sustained as viable in equilibrium.
- **Strategic entry:** Extends the logic to the elite/supply side—candidates, party leaders, and contributors likewise anticipate viability and decide whether to enter or exit a race; entry decisions interact with (and can substitute or reinforce) voter-side strategic desertion in producing the $M + 1$ outcome.
- **Conditions for successful (Duvergerian) coordination:** Common knowledge/expectations about relative candidate viability (e.g., via credible polling or a track record of past results), sufficiently long time horizons/electoral experience, and broadly shared (single-peaked, unidimensional-type) preference structures across the relevant electorate.
- **Coordination failures theorized:** When these conditions are not met—new or volatile electorates, absent or unreliable polling, multidimensional or regionally fragmented preferences, or elites with non-electoral motives for entering—coordination can fail, sustaining

more than $M + 1$ viable candidates; this reframes classic “exceptions” to Duverger’s Law (e.g., persistent third parties in some plurality systems) as theoretically expected outcomes under specifiable conditions rather than anomalies.

- **From district to national outcomes:** Notes that even perfect district-level Duvergerian coordination does not by itself imply a small *national* party system, since different districts could each reduce to a different pair/set of $M + 1$ parties—setting up the book’s second theoretical pillar on cross-district (upper-tier) coordination developed in Part II/III.

6 Part II: Applications I — Testing the $M + 1$ Rule (Plurality, SNTV, STV Cases)

- **Plurality systems revisited (Britain, Canada, and others):** Empirically tests district-level convergence toward two viable candidates, and examines cases of persistent multi-candidate viability (e.g., regionally based third parties) as instances of coordination failure driven by geographically concentrated, locally common information that differs from national-level expectations.
- **India as a hard test:** Uses India’s large number of single-member districts and heterogeneous, historically inexperienced electorate to test whether coordination failure is systematically more common where the conditions for common expectations (stable competitive experience, reliable local information) are weaker—finding substantial district-level deviation from strict two-candidate competition where those conditions are absent.
- **SNTV in Japan and Taiwan:** The book’s signature multi-member test—under SNTV, the dominant party (LDP in Japan) must solve a delicate internal coordination problem, nominating and supporting exactly enough co-partisan candidates in each multi-member district to capture available seats without splitting the party’s own vote so finely that some co-partisans lose; documents both successful party-level vote-management strategies and instances of failure (too many or too few candidates).
- **STV and other multi-member preferential systems:** Extends the logic to systems with vote transfers (e.g., Ireland), testing whether the $M + 1$ boundary on viable first-preference candidates holds even where lower-ranked preferences can be transferred, refining the scope conditions of the rule.
- **Cross-national statistical tests:** Presents broad comparative regression evidence that the (effective) number of candidates/parties competing at the district level rises systematically with district magnitude M , consistent with the $M + 1$ logic, while also documenting substantial and theoretically explicable variance around the predicted value.

7 Part III: Applications II — Cross-District Coordination and National Party Systems

- **From district-level to national-level party systems:** Develops the theory of **linkage**—the conditions under which winners in different districts coordinate around the *same* small set of national party labels, so that many local Duvergerian ($M + 1$) outcomes aggregate into a nationally consolidated party system rather than a fragmented one.
- **Determinants of linkage:** National party organizational strength, resource pooling and centralized nomination/campaign finance, shared partisan labels with national reputational value, and (crucially) the design of **upper-tier** seat allocation in mixed-member systems, which can either reinforce or cross-cut lower-tier district incentives.
- **Mixed-member systems and upper-tier design:** Analyzes how the interaction between lower-tier district magnitude and upper-tier (compensatory or parallel) seat allocation shapes incentives for cross-district coordination—e.g., whether small parties have incentive to coordinate strategically across the whole system to clear upper-tier thresholds, versus running fragmented, purely local campaigns.
- **Presidential elections and coattail coordination:** Develops and tests the claim that a concurrent, national, single-prize ($M = 1$) presidential contest exerts a powerful *coordinating* pull on legislative party systems, pushing them toward two dominant blocs even where legislative district magnitude alone would not predict such consolidation—engaging and refining the existing literature on presidential coattail effects (e.g., in Latin American presidential democracies).
- **Latin American and other presidential/mixed cases (e.g., Chile, Colombia, Brazil):** Used to test the interaction of presidential coordination, legislative district magnitude, and party organizational strength in shaping the actual size of national party systems, showing substantial cross-national variation explicable by these combined factors.

8 Conclusion

- **Synthesis:** Restates the book’s integrated framework—the number of parties/candidates actually competing is jointly determined by the number of socially salient cleavages/interests, the permissiveness of electoral institutions (chiefly district magnitude, but also upper-tier design and presidentialism), and the success or failure of strategic coordination among voters and elites under specifiable informational and experiential conditions.
- **Generalization of Duverger:** Emphasizes that Duverger’s Law and Hypothesis are not two separate empirical regularities but two instances of the single underlying $M + 1$ logic, unified by treating district magnitude as a continuous institutional variable rather than sorting systems into a plurality/PR dichotomy.

- **Scope conditions and limits:** Reiterates that the theory predicts *when* coordination should succeed or fail (new vs. established democracies, availability of common information, homogeneity of preferences), rather than treating all deviations from $M + 1$ as unexplained noise—a key methodological contribution distinguishing the book from earlier, more mechanical readings of Duverger.
- **Legacy and influence:** Positions the book as establishing the dominant contemporary framework for the comparative study of party system size, subsequently extended by a large empirical literature testing the $M + 1$ rule, upper-tier linkage, and coattail effects across many additional electoral systems and elections.